



Understanding Consumer Rights

When starting a business, you need to recognize your legal duties toward customers. From the outset, make sure you are aware of consumer legislation, which affects both goods and services.

Selling products

Consumer laws protect consumers against unfair selling practices and unscrupulous vendors. Wherever your business operates, you need to understand the rights your customers enjoy under national and local law. These rulings are encompassed not just in consumer legislation but also, for example, in food safety, electronics, and labeling laws.

In the US, individual states apply their own rules in addition to national law. However, legislation can be shared between nations, as it is for member countries of the European Union. There are also increasing efforts to internationalize consumer law, particularly because of global trade via the internet. The International Consumer Protection and Enforcement Network

A customer's basic consumer rights

Government bodies and consumer watchdog groups firmly defend consumer rights and will investigate unresolved complaints against businesses. Before you start selling, check local and national government websites (see pp.212–215), and those of consumer-championing organizations, for guidance and information relevant to your type of business. Rights will vary from state to state, and even region to region, but are likely to cover the same fundamentals of buying goods or services—quality, being fit for purpose, delivery, returns, and repairs. If you sell handbags, for example, you would have to meet consumer rights in all these areas.

QUALITY

The goods you sell should be as described and be of good quality. A "leather bag," for example, should not contain synthetic components.

DELIVERY

You are responsible for your goods until they are in a customer's hands. If there are delivery problems, you will have to deal with them, even if the fault lies with the courier.

